

« I went through a bit of an existential crisis
after Candidates disappointment »

VIDIT GUJRATHI

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Daily, thousands from around the world gather to capture a photo with Mumbai's iconic Gateway of India.

So, it wasn't hard to convince Vidit Gujrathi to step out of the Gateway-facing Taj Mahal Palace Hotel for a quick photo before the Sportstar Aces 2025 awards night. Even as one of the world's top chess players, the tourist in him remains very much alive.

The brief photo session was soon interrupted by surprised chess fans. Vidit, momentarily taken aback by the quick recognition, smiled and graciously posed for selfies.

Back inside the hotel, we settled in for a long, insightful conversation — covering his Candidates 2024 campaign, his 'tech' aspirations, and the 'low-key' 2025 he has planned.

The Candidates Tournament was the highlight of 2024 for you. What were your key learnings from it?

I remember how incredible it felt when I qualified for the Candidates after winning the FIDE Grand Swiss. It was a euphoric moment because we had been preparing so intensely for it. I put my heart and soul into chess for nearly two years.

Once I qualified, I completely shut out the world. I went off social media and focused entirely on chess. I invested a lot of money into training because I didn't want any regrets. I'm very proud that I gave it my all.

There were highs and lows in the Candidates. It started well — I was the first player to win a game. However, the problem was that I failed to convert several winning positions. Against [Fabiano] Caruana and [Ian] Nepomniachtchi, for

example, I couldn't hold onto my advantage when those winning positions arrived.

Looking back, do you think there was anything you could have done differently in your preparation?

Possibly. I was mainly working on the technical aspects of my game, but I could have focused more on the mental side — perhaps some mental conditioning coaching. I think that's where I fell short in crucial moments. I was extremely composed in some games, like my wins against Hikaru [Nakamura], but I struggled to maintain that consistency. That's what bothers me now when I reflect on it.

Is that something you plan to work on in the future?

Yes, of course. It's a never-ending

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Favourite chess format

Blitz

Favourite opening move

E4

Dream location to play chess

A Rajasthani palace

One chess rule change you would make

Increase the King's powers

A famous person, dead or alive, you would want to play chess with

Gautama Buddha

If you could change one move from the past...

vs Ian Nepomniachtchi in Candidates 2024